



MENTAL STRENGTH

Managing Perfectionism



Perfectionism

‘Perfection is an unattainable and unsustainable goal, which can be detrimental to well-being and resilience.’



Can you give examples of any perfectionist behaviours?



What is driving your desire for perfection?



What impact does your perfectionism have on you and others?

Can you give examples of any perfectionist behaviours?

- Difficulty starting or completing tasks, giving up too easily, procrastination.
- Overly cautious in tasks.
- Excessive checking.
- Constantly trying to improve things.
- Avoiding trying new things.

What is driving your desire for perfection?

- Fear of failure.
- Fear of making mistakes.
- Fear of being judged and criticised.
- Setting yourself unrealistically high standards.
- Perceived expectations of others.

What impact does your perfectionism have on you and others?

- Constant checking and re-working of emails / reports / proposals.
- Difficulty finishing tasks.
- Missed deadlines.
- Reluctance to delegate / relinquish control.
- Expectation of impossibly high standards from others.

Drivers of Perfectionism

The 3 types of perfectionism



SELF-ORIENTED

Setting impossibly high standards for yourself.



OTHER-ORIENTED

Setting impossibly high expectations for others.



SOCIALLY PRESCRIBED

Assuming others have expectations of you that are impossible to meet.

Rnic et al, 2021



“When we work without fear of failure, the focus is on learning or achievement rather than avoiding failure, so pursuing challenging goals is energising rather than exhausting”

source: Dunkley 2003, Stoltz 2007



ADAPTIVE V MALADAPTIVE PERFECTIONISM

Setting high standards and aiming for success can help us deliver on our goals and drive development, growth, and performance (Adaptive Perfectionism).

But excessively high standards, self-critical evaluation, fear of others' expectations and judgement, can affect well-being, relationships, and careers (Maladaptive).

Impact of Perfectionism in The Workplace

Research in the US on perfectionism in the workplace found that amongst participants:

86%

believe perfectionist expectations impact their work.

72%

believe perfectionism is harmful to relationship-building.

68%

believe perfectionism leads to burnout.

66%

believe perfectionism leads to fear of failure and conflict avoidance.

66%

of workplaces struggle with perfectionism.

1/3

of employees are considering leaving their workplace because of perfectionist expectations.

Northern Carolina University & Hardin Group 2022



Perfectionism



What could you do differently?



What are the potential advantages of letting go of perfectionism?

What could you do differently?

- Recognise that perfection is an unattainable and unsustainable goal.
- Accept more time spent does not necessarily lead to better quality.
- Stop making revisions, ask a colleague to review a piece of work to see if its good enough.
- Resist spending more time on something, it could be counterproductive.
- Focus on maximising the impact of your work, concentrate on what's important in the time available.

What are the potential advantages of letting go of perfectionism?

- More time for the things you enjoy.
- Easier to get started on and complete tasks.
- Increased productivity.
- Improved well-being.
- Improved personal and professional relationships.

BEST PRACTICE

Managing Perfectionism

High standards can motivate and encourage us towards our goals, but they must be realistic.



Challenge any unrealistic standards you set for yourself.



Set achievable benchmarks with realistic goals, breaking larger tasks into manageable steps.



Set a time limit for a piece of work and stick to it.



Calibrate your standards by asking a trusted colleague for feedback.



Stop over-delivering.



Resist spending more time on something, it could be counterproductive.

BEST PRACTICE

Managing Perfectionism



Celebrate when you successfully modify your perfectionism.



Become comfortable with imperfection- mistakes can lead to development and growth.



Recognise the point of diminishing returns when you're aiming to complete a task perfectly.



Submit a piece of work without spending hours editing it and see if anyone notices.



Re-assign tasks if your time is better spent elsewhere, even if you find it difficult to relinquish control.



Build a support network of colleagues, mentors or friends who may have experienced similar challenges.

EXERCISES

Perfectionism



EXERCISE 1

Re-evaluate your perfectionist standards

In this first exercise you will be asked to consider whether you have higher standards than others and what they are, whether they help or get in the way of achieving your goals, and the implications of relaxing those perfectionist standards. This will help you gain perspective on how perfectionism is impacting your life.

Review your answers – does perfectionism have a negative impact on your life?

Are your standards higher than other people's? In which aspects are they higher?

Do you manage to always achieve the standards you set for yourself?

Do others always manage to achieve the standards you set them?

Are your standards a help or a hindrance to achieving your goals?

What are the possible outcomes of relaxing those standards?

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EXERCISE 2

Identify your perfectionist behaviours and beliefs

Use the table to identify and focus on the areas that impact you most and that you would like to work on. You will be asked to work on one of these areas in Exercise 3.

Example table:

ENVIRONMENT	TASK OR ACTIVITY	YOUR PERFECTIONIST BELIEF	HOW CONFIDENT ARE YOU IN YOUR BELIEF? (1-100%)
Work	Report writing	Unless I check and re-work this more than 10 times it will be sub-standard and rejected by my line manager	95%
Work	Working hours	Unless I work 75 hours/week I will not produce quality work	90%
Exercise	Gym	Unless I go to the gym 7 days/week I won't be fit and healthy	95%

ENVIRONMENT	TASK OR ACTIVITY	YOUR PERFECTIONIST BELIEF	HOW CONFIDENT ARE YOU IN YOUR BELIEF? (1-100%)

Perfectionism



EXERCISE 3

Challenge One of Your Perfectionist Beliefs

Using one of the perfectionist beliefs you described in Exercise 2, you can apply the following process to determine whether the extra time you spend pursuing perfectionism is necessary.

Try to accept the feelings that this exercise may provoke such as anxiety, discomfort or self-criticism.

By challenging perfectionist beliefs, you can start a change in the associated behaviours.



1. IDENTIFY A BELIEF

Choose one perfectionist belief from Exercise 2 which you would like to work on.

Example:

“Unless I check and re-work this more than ten times it will be sub-standard and rejected by my line manager”.



2. EXPERIMENT

Select 2 similar tasks -complete the first as you would normally, but for the second task decrease your time allowance.

Example:

With the next two reports I will check/ rework the first at least ten times and with the second I will limit myself to only one initial check, one rework and one final check before submitting it.



3. RESULTS

Record the success of both tasks and how they were received.

Example:

The line manager found both reports acceptable.



4. HOW CONFIDENT WERE YOU?

In Exercise 2 what was your answer to how confident you were in your perfectionist belief?

Example:

I was 95% confident that the report would not be acceptable if I did not check it more than ten times.



5. HOW CONFIDENT ARE YOU NOW?

After the results of your experiment, how confident are you now in your perfectionist belief?

Example:

I am now only 40% confident in my perfectionist belief. I think that the majority of future reports which have reduced checks and reworks will be accepted.



6. CONCLUSION

If you managed to complete a task in less time and remain successful, how might this affect future behaviour?

Example:

The report on which I spent less time was still of a high quality and time was freed up to be used on another task.

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EXERCISE 4 Goal Setting

Decide what you would like to change, how that change would look, and the goals that you need to set yourself in order to achieve it.

AREA I WOULD LIKE TO ADDRESS	AIM	MEASURABLE GOALS
Balancing the need for detail with completing a task on time	Produce a high standard of work without missing deadlines	Set a time limit for fact finding / data sourcing Let go of irrelevant details Focus on what is important/needed Recognise what good looks like in your organisation. Enlist the help of others and trust them to produce the required standard. Meet the deadline.
Difficulty relinquishing control of tasks- reluctance to prioritise makes it difficult to let go of or reassign unimportant tasks and relinquish control.	To concentrate on tasks where I can add value and that align with my skill set.	Re-assign tasks if your time is better spent elsewhere. Don't expect perfection in others.
Exercise Schedule - expecting 100% success all the time with achieving exercise targets.	To accept that no-one can be 100% successful 100% of the time and to celebrate partial successes.	Set a target e.g. going to the gym 5 times a week. Record how often you go. Even if you only go twice that week, see it as a success, twice is better than not at all, it still has value and you can feel good about it.

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EXERCISE 5 Practice Self-compassion

Decide what you would like to change, how that change would look and the goals that you need to set yourself in order to achieve it.

Completing this exercise will demonstrate that by shifting to a more compassionate voice you will be able to achieve more with the time available, achieve your goals and have increased focus, well-being and productivity.

AREA OF CONCERN <i>Identify an area in which you may be setting high standards for yourself.</i>	YOUR CURRENT STANDARD/ EXPECTATION <i>State your current standard or expectation within the area that you would like to work on.</i>	IS THIS STANDARD UNREASONABLE IF APPLIED TO A COLLEAGUE/ FRIEND? <i>Apply your standard to a colleague or friend and consider if its reasonable or unreasonably high.</i>	ALTERNATIVE NEW STANDARD <i>Decide what would be an acceptable standard.</i>	WHAT IMPACT WOULD THE NEW STANDARD HAVE? <i>What would be the implications if you applied this new standard?</i>
Writing an internal email.	This needs to be re-worked/ checked 5 times to be of a sufficient standard so that I don't make a mistake.	YES	To limit myself to one re-working / check before it is sent.	The email will still be accurate and informative and I will have more time to progress other work.
Preparing a customer presentation.	Every available source needs to be researched and incorporated into the presentation.	YES	To spend sufficient time on research to get a broad overview of the subject, in order to be able to present the salient points.	The presentation will be easier for customers to understand as it will not include unnecessary detail and will be a better use of the time.